DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Does God Really Have Attributes?

Daat Tevunot §156-157

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §156-157
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 20 July 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The final part of Section 7

This class finishes Section 7. We have seen how Hashem's mishpat is fundamental, how it flows from love, and how it creates more physical and more spiritual beings. The Ramhal now ends with something we already know but must keep in mind: everything said about Hashem's attributes is only from the point of view of how we receive it. "God has no attributes."

Attributes are what He does, not what He is

The Sekhel says (§156) that Hashem is hidden from His creatures' understanding, and His essence cannot be grasped at all, because our intelligence is physical. But He chose to send out emanations, and through them we describe Him with many adjectives and tell His praises as far as we are able.

A person's traits (kind or cruel, humble or arrogant, thrifty or extravagant) are additions to the soul. The soul does not have to be kind. That is one more thing about it. With Hashem there is no such comparison. We can only say that He acts through these middot, not that they are qualities added to His essence, God forbid, because He is free of anything we can grasp.

So what do we mean when we say the 13 attributes of mercy? We mean that Hashem relates to us in a merciful way, that He has created an emanation of mercy. There are not 13 attributes in God, "because that denies the Yihud of Hashem". The Rambam explains this at length in Moreh Nevuchim, and the Rabbi pointed out that this is only the second time the Ramhal mentions him in the book.

The sunglasses analogy

The Rabbi repeated an analogy. There is one sunlight. Put on green glasses and you see green light, red glasses and you see red. The light is the same, but how you receive it depends on the glasses. Hashem's light and emanation are one. He has created different "glasses", different ways for us to perceive it. These middot were created according to our needs.

The sefirot are a hierarchy for us

The Ramhal says the attributes are arranged in a hierarchy, one above the other. The Rabbi explained that this refers to the ten sefirot of Kabbalah, from Keter at the top down through Yesod to Malkhut. But they are not parts of God or levels within Him, God forbid. "That's complete Christianity." He quoted the Tashbes, who was no friend of Kabbalah and wrote that those who speak of ten sefirot are worse than the Christians who speak of three. We must be careful to speak of them only as emanations.

A participant asked whether the 13 attributes appear in every sefirah. The Rabbi said yes. The sefirot are the hierarchy, and within each one the attributes can be understood in different ways. From Hashem's side there is no hierarchy at all. "It's all one light."

How the attributes connect

Each attribute is distinct, yet they are linked like the rings of a chain. The Ramhal quotes the Rambam on "I will make all My goodness pass before you": Hashem would show Moshe all of existence, its nature and how each part connects to the next. Some attributes are linked as cause and effect. Some work together as partners. Some give and some receive. The Rabbi gave Hesed and Gevurah as examples, with others in the middle that connect them.

The Ramhal illustrates with the mind. To understand something, a person first pictures it in his imagination, which on its own is "just a dream". Then he brings in his understanding to take it apart and put it back together. One faculty is expressed through another, and that is a connection of middot. The principle, said the Rabbi, is the whole of Kabbalah: each lower level comes from the higher, and the higher must reach down into the lower. That is why we say "leshem yihud", for the sake of uniting the parts.

Within this structure there are emanations of the first mode, judgment, which make good and bad possible, and of the second mode, sovereignty, which completes all deficiencies. Within judgment, some emanations are on the side of Hesed, some on the left and some in the middle. Some darken things and some only give light.

Understanding the physical world

To understand all this, one must know the roots and the branches. The Rabbi stressed that this is why the Hakhamim valued knowledge of the physical world. If you do not understand how the physical world connects, you cannot begin to understand the spiritual. Even a simple comparison, like the gulf between a donkey and a dolphin, is a start. He recalled that when they learned about nevuah, a prophet needed to understand the world, and the Rambam is even clearer that a prophet must know the sciences. He regretted that modern education specialises so narrowly, where older training was far more holistic.

A participant added that we influence the higher levels by doing good, not by understanding them, and the Rabbi agreed. At the end of the day we cannot fully understand. We affect the system through our deeds.

End of Section 7

In §157 the Neshamah thanks the Sekhel for lifting it out of great doubts and asks him to finish. That ends Section 7. The Rabbi asked the group to use the summer to review the summary of Section 7 and of all seven sections before Section 8 begins around Elul.

Summary

- Hashem has no attributes in Himself. The middot describe how He acts towards us, not what He is.
- Like sunlight through coloured glasses, one divine light is received in many ways.
- The sefirot are a hierarchy only from our side. Treating them as parts of God would deny His Yihud.
- The attributes are linked like a chain, through cause and effect, partnership, giving and receiving.
- Understanding the physical world is the start of understanding the spiritual one, but we affect it through good deeds.

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